

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump said he would soon “make a determination” regarding American [arms sales to Taiwan](#), but “made no commitment either way” when discussing the island’s defence with **Xi Jinping**. China earlier warned America that the issue could result in “conflict” if “mishandled”. America’s president also said he might lift sanctions on Chinese oil refiners that purchased Iranian oil. Few deals emerged from [the two-day summit](#).

Abbas Araghchi, Iran’s foreign minister, said that America’s “contradictory messages” scuppered his country’s “trust” in negotiations. He said America needed to get “serious”. On Friday **Mr Trump** said a 20-year moratorium on **Iran’s** nuclear programme would be enough for him to end the war. He had previously maintained that he would accept nothing short of a surrender of Iran’s nuclear ambitions.

Israel and **Lebanon** agreed to extend their ceasefire for 45 days, America’s State Department said. It described talks between the two sides, held in Washington on Thursday and Friday, as “highly productive”—despite almost daily reports of Hizbullah and Israel trading fire across southern Lebanon. Political talks are scheduled to continue in June, with a security track starting at the end of May.

Britain's borrowing costs rose after **Andy Burnham**, Manchester's mayor, secured a path to challenge Sir Keir Starmer for leadership of the Labour Party. Mr Burnham will stand in a by-election after the incumbent resigned to make way for him (challengers to the prime minister must be MPS). [Political uncertainty](#) has helped push yields on 30-year gilts close to their highest level in almost 30 years.

An **Ebola** outbreak killed 65 people in the Democratic Republic of Congo. Nearly 250 cases have been reported in the Ituri province on the border with Uganda and South Sudan. Africa's health agency warned that it could spread rapidly because of intense population movement in the area. It is the 17th outbreak of the deadly virus in the country since 1976.

Russia and **Ukraine** swapped hundreds of prisoners of war as part of a deal brokered by Mr Trump earlier this month. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said it was part of a bigger swap expected to involve 2,000 prisoners. Still, fighting has been intense: earlier this week Russia carried out the largest sustained attack on Ukraine since the war began, firing more than 1,500 drones.

Mr Trump said he will open a sculpture garden of American "heroes" in West Potomac Park in Washington, DC, which he described as a "totally BARREN field of prime waterfront real estate". (It sits near a public golf course where Mr Trump dumped debris from his White House renovation.) The president set aside \$40m for the development in his [Big Beautiful Bill](#) last year.

Figure of the day: 55%, the full-time employment rate for Americans who graduated in 2025 in the fields most exposed to AI, down from 70% in 2022. Read [our analysis](#) of whether the technology is putting graduates out of work.



Photograph: Alamy

Regime change at the Fed

A high-stakes transition is under way at America's Federal Reserve. On Friday [Kevin Warsh](#) replaces Jerome Powell as chair of the world's most powerful central bank. Donald Trump has repeatedly demanded lower interest rates, raising fears about the Fed's independence. Mr Warsh secured the nomination in part by bending his hawkish stance closer to that of the dove-in-chief at the White House.

But the Fed's credibility may endure. Mr Warsh's ideas for "regime change" have proved less radical than feared. They focus on shrinking the Fed's balance-sheet, overhauling its communications and broadening the use of alternative data sources. Meanwhile higher inflation, caused by the war in Iran, has weakened the case for rate cuts. In April Scott Bessent, the treasury secretary, offered Mr Warsh political cover by urging the Fed to "wait and see" before cutting. Can Mr Warsh withstand the fury of the president? His first policy meeting is in June. Investors will be watching closely.



Photograph: Getty Images

Palestinians mourn the Nakba

On Friday Palestinians commemorate the Nakba, the mass displacement and dispossession that accompanied Israel's creation in 1948. For many, that war never ended. Israel's right-wing government is entrenching its occupation of the West Bank; its army controls most of [Gaza](#). Materials to rebuild the enclave are barred. Ministers openly muse about evicting Palestinians who remain.

In decades past Palestinians looked to Fatah, a dominant nationalist group, for liberation. But under Mahmoud Abbas, the Palestinian Authority's 90-year-old president, the movement is sclerotic and powerless. After five years of delay, Fatah is choosing a new governing body from Thursday to Saturday. Few expect renewal: most delegates owe their positions to Mr Abbas. They are gathering in four cities, highlighting Palestinians' fragmentation.

Marches are expected in Jerusalem's Old City, the Palestinians' putative capital. But they will be led by Jewish nationalists celebrating Israel's conquest of Arab East Jerusalem in 1967. Palestinians mourning the Nakba there are likely to do so in silence.



Photograph: Getty Images

The energy shock hits India

India has been among the countries worst affected by the Gulf war, and things are deteriorating still. This week Narendra Modi asked Indians to work from home and forgo foreign travel to conserve fuel. On Friday the prime minister travelled to the United Arab Emirates for talks that could [alleviate the pain](#). India is expected to sign deals to lock in supplies of liquefied petroleum gas, which is used for cooking, and to bolster its strategic oil reserves.

That may eventually provide relief, but more pressing concerns loom. The rupee sank to a record low against the dollar this week, making crude imports—which account for around 90% of India's consumption—costlier still. After weeks of absorbing that cost, state-owned energy firms raised petrol and diesel prices on Friday for the first time since the war began. Mr Modi has called for austerity from the public; now his government may need some of its own.



Photograph: Disney Plus

“Rivals” is smutty, sexist, snobbish and superb

“Rivals”, a smash-hit bonkbuster based on stories by the late [Dame Jilly Cooper](#), returns to streaming services for a second season on Friday. In the finale of the first, Tony Baddingham, a villainous media baron played deliciously by David Tennant, was knocked out with a statuette. He swiftly recovers to keep his end up—and get it away—in his continuing tussle with a thrusting television presenter (Aidan Turner) and a priapic toff (Alex Hassell).

Fans will be relieved to find the show’s formula unchanged. It still has a banging soundtrack to match its setting in the 1980s. Notionally the plot involves a battle over TV franchises, but again the real action is in the bedroom (and in a jacuzzi, on top of a piano, and so on). “Rivals” has the structure of a murder mystery—except the question is not who will be bumped off, but who will next bonk whom.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which musician sang a duet with Stevie Wonder called “Ebony and Ivory”?

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Forever is composed of nows.

Emily Dickinson